

# AFL Data Foundations — Data Dictionary & Target Contract (v1)

Source coverage: 1983–2025. Match target is defined at match level; top-player targets are defined at player-in-match level. The contract is designed for leakage-safe Day 2 modeling.

| Target                    | Definition / formula                                                  | Level        |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|
| target_home_win           | 1 when home team wins; 0 otherwise.                                   | Match        |
| target_draw               | 1 when match is a draw; 0 otherwise.                                  | Match        |
| target_margin             | Home score – away score.                                              | Match        |
| top_disposal_player_id    | Player with max disposals in the match; ties → lowest player_id.      | Player-match |
| top_goal_kicker_player_id | Player with max goals in the match; ties → lowest player_id.          | Player-match |
| top_fantasy_player_id     | Player with max fantasy_points in the match; ties → lowest player_id. | Player-match |

## Core pre-match features

**Form:** prior 5-game win rate (draw=0.5), average points for/against, and win streak. **Context:** rest days, venue, season-to-date ladder points/position, prior H2H win rate and H2H game count. **Leakage rule:** current match score/result is appended to histories only after the current row's features are created.

## Data limitations

Player-position labels, weather and geographic travel distance are not present in the supplied tables, so position/travel/weather effects are not claimed. Historical club aliases exist; whitespace is stripped and W. Bulldogs is normalized to Western Bulldogs. Draws are retained rather than silently converted to wins.

## Split contract

Train on seasons before the latest season; hold out the latest season (2025 in this dataset). A random split can leak future-era information into training. Near-perfect sports prediction would be a leakage warning, not a success criterion.